Major General Niranjan Prasad's actions were symptomatic of the complete collapse of coherent thinking along the entire chain of command. Lieutenant General Kaul, the IV Corps Commander, was ill. In his absence, the BGS, Brigadier K. K. Singh, had time and again demonstrated that Corps HQ was incapable of taking even the most minor decision; the Eastern Army Commander, Lieutenant General Sen, after insisting at the prime minister's residence on 11 October that 7 Brigade must stand its ground, had also refused to take charge of the situation.

More than a thousand kilometres away, the IB director, B. N. Mullik, sitting behind his desk in South Block, had the most accurate picture of the developing situation in Khenzemane and the Nam Ka Chu Valley. While Military Intelligence was out of the loop, the Directorate of Military Operations was aware that by the time army communication networks coded and decoded their signals, the situation would have changed. The IB operative sitting in Zimithang at Division HQ was privy to all the information that was coming in and was directly communicating the situation to Mullik. By midday, he had informed Delhi that Khenzemane, Dhola and Tsangdhar, after offering brief resistance, had been overrun. Just why and how Niranjan Prasad, sitting a few yards away from the same communication hub, failed to grasp this will always remain one of the unsolved mysteries of 1962.

The loss of both his helicopters had made the situation even more difficult for Niranjan Prasad as he was now without any transport. With 7 Brigade wiped out, the next task was to counter the immediate developing threat to Tawang.

Meanwhile, 4 Grenadiers and 9 Punjab after their withdrawal from Bridge 1 and Bridge 2 continued to climb towards the ridgeline that connected Hathung-la with Karpo-la 1 in isolated groups. The two commanding officers, Lieutenant Colonels Harihar Singh and Mishra, had caught up with each other on 22 October. Concerned only with their own safety, they had made good their own escape to the plains of Assam through Bhutan leaving their two battalions to their fate. In a damning indictment of the two commanding officers, Captain Amarinder Singh writes: 'Unbelievably, that was the last the Battalion saw of them until the main body met up with them again at the Brigade Concentration Point at Ramgarh in Bihar, three weeks later.' It would take another seventeen days for the Grenadiers to get back to India via Bhutan. Under the circumstances,